FT FollowThrough

The Plumbing Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- What's happening: a leak, a clog, no hot water, or something new to install?
- Is water coming out right now? If so, walk them to the shut-off valve first.
- Do you own the home, or should I talk to the landlord or property manager too?
- Can you send a photo of the problem and of the water heater label?

> "Thanks for calling [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me what's going on and I'll see how we can help."

> "Can you send me a photo? I can be there today between 2 and 4 or tomorrow at 8. Which works better?"

2. Presenting the quote

- Give a flat price per task before you start, not an open-ended hourly bill.
- Show photos of what you found: corroded pipe, the failed part, the camera footage.
- Itemize parts, code parts (expansion tank, valves), permit, haul-away and labor warranty.
- Say in writing what happens if you find more, like a broken line behind a clog: you stop, show photos and price it first.

> "Here's what I found, here's how I'd fix it, and here's the flat price. I can do it today if you'd like. What questions do you have?"

3. The 7 objections plumbers hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. "Another plumber quoted less."
"That's fair, I'd compare too. Does their price include the permit, code parts like an expansion tank, hauling away the old heater and a labor warranty? That's where plumbing quotes differ. Send it over and I'll mark the differences for you."

2. "I have to check with the property owner."
"Of course, it's their call. What do they usually need to approve a repair? I'll send photos, the price and what happens if it waits, so you can forward it today."

3. "Can you do it cheaper if I buy the part?"
"I can install a part you buy. Which one did you have in mind? I just can't warranty a part I didn't supply, so if it fails you'd pay for labor twice. I'll write up both prices so you can decide."

4. "I'll just pour drain cleaner down it."
"Lots of people try that first. How long has it been slow? Chemical cleaners can damage older pipes and won't clear roots or a broken line. If it comes back, I'll clear it and run a camera so you can see what's really there."

5. “It’s only a small drip, I’ll deal with it later.”
“Understood, it doesn’t look urgent. Do you know how long it’s been dripping? Slow leaks under a cabinet or slab can rot the floor and grow mold before you see them. I can give you a flat price to fix it today.”

6. “How do I know I won’t get a surprise bill?”
“Fair worry, plumbers hear it a lot. What happened last time? I give you the flat price before I start, and if I find something else, I stop and show you photos before doing more.”

7. “Why do you need a deposit for the re-pipe?”
“The deposit covers the pipe and fittings so they’re on site on day one. What payment schedule works for you? It’s in the contract, and the balance is due after the inspection passes and you’ve checked the work.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the quote for the [job] come through okay? Happy to answer any questions.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], checking in on the [job]. I have a spot on [day] and can hold it for you until Friday.”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday. If anything starts leaking again in the meantime, call me and I’ll come out first.”

A “not now” on a big job often turns into a yes after the next leak. Save every quote and check in when the weather turns cold.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask right after the job, when they’re happiest, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with the work, would you leave a quick Google review? I’ll text you the link. And if a friend has a plumbing problem, I’d be glad to help.”

Put a sticker with your number on the water heater or under the sink. The next time something leaks, it’s the first number they see.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- Check your state’s plumbing license before you quote, pull permits, and never let an unregistered helper work alone.
- Get insurance that covers water damage and finished work. A failed fitting weeks later is the claim you most need covered.
- Write that camera inspections and extra repairs are separate, and get approval before any extra work.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.
The full start-up guide for plumbers: followthroughguides.com/plumbing · Questions: info@followthroughguides.com